EDUCATIONAL SAMPLE MATERIAL. Written for testing the TACTIQ indexing pipeline. It describes general tactical concepts only. It contains no real match data, no statistics and no observations about real teams or players.

COUNTERPRESSING

Counterpressing (also called gegenpressing) means pressing the ball immediately after losing it. The players closest to the ball try to win it back within a few seconds, before the opponent can look up and start a counter-attack.

Why it can work: at the moment a team wins the ball it is often still in a defensive shape, and its players may not yet be positioned to attack. Pressing at once can catch the opponent in this unstable moment.

Requirements and risks

Counterpressing works best when players are close to each other when the ball is lost, so several of them can press together. If the distances are large, one player pressing alone is easily bypassed.

If counterpressing fails, the opponent may find space to counter-attack. Teams therefore combine it with rest defence: a few players stay behind the ball to protect against counter-attacks.

Analysis note: event data can show possession regains shortly after losses. The distances between players at the moment of the loss normally require tracking data or video.